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THE VOICE EXPRESS GAZETTE

EDUCATION

# “Professor Subramanian is Being Targeted Because She Dared to Call Out the Relationship of the Indian Caste System with Vedic Mathematics”

*Ohio State mathematics education professor Theodore Chao's eyewitness testimony of Dr. Jayasree Subramanian's expulsion from the 15th International Congress on Mathematical Education in Sydney — removed from the conference for questioning the caste politics embedded in a session promoting Vedic mathematics.*

BY THEODORE CHAO

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ABOUT

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# Theodore Chao's Testimony of Professor Jayasree Subramanian's Actions in the Session "Reviving Ancient Wisdom: Vedic Mathematics for Modern Learning" Facilitated by Ashish Arora

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*This testimony was written in defense of Professor Jayasree Subramanian, who was expelled from the recently held 15th ICME in Sydney due to the incident described above. Chao's testimony has been widely circulated through academic circles, & is largely responsible for shedding light on the controversy.*

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My name is Theodore Chao and I am a professor of mathematics education at the Ohio State University. I am honored to be an invited speaker at the International Congress of Mathematics Education (ICME) conference in Sydney, Australia in 2024. This is my second ICME conference and I came because I love hearing and discussing global perspectives of mathematics education and learning to eradicate past injustices. Yesterday, July 12, I attended a 9:00 AM session titled, 'Reviving Ancient Wisdom: Vedic Mathematics for Modern Learning', facilitated by Professor Ashish Arora of I. K. Gujral Punjab Technical University.

*I attended the session because I was interested in cultural ways of thinking about mathematics and mathematics teaching practices, particularly ones that come from non-Eurocentric backgrounds. My limited understanding of Indian mathematics history made me curious to attend this session and I did so with an open mind, without assumptions that there might be issues of injustice and oppression within what would be presented as Vedic mathematics.*

*Personally, I found the session to be quite disappointing, but not terrible. Professor Arora only briefly spoke about the origins of Vedic mathematics and the different mathematicians who were considered Vedic mathematicians in India. I wish he had spent more time on speaking about and engaging us in discussion about the cultural history of mathematics, as this was supposed to be a workshop session. But he quickly glossed through this history in about 15 or 20 minutes.*

Then, Professor Arora introduced various mathematics procedures framed as particular aspects of Vedic mathematics. I would have found these procedures fascinating if we had time to unpack them, play with them, and discuss their histories. Instead, Professor Arora jumped into examples and specific details about the way to use these procedures in isolated ways, unconnected to real-world mathematics. I tried to follow along with various ways that he presented specific values within algorithms that would lead to multiplication. Personally, I found these examples to be quite boring because Professor Arora seemed to be lecturing and just walking through the examples quickly without really interacting with the audience. In fact, I even intervened to move the whiteboard he was using to a space that was more well-lit and visible to the rest of the room to make this lecture a little more engaging to the audience. I was disappointed because it felt very much like a traditional (not in a good way) college mathematics lecture, one in which the professor did not seem interested in connecting with the audience or even listening to what the audience was thinking.

This is an aspect of this workshop that I found frustrating. To me, the main point of the ICME conference is to explore and discuss mathematics education together. Therefore, having space to engage in the study of mathematics pedagogy and the ways that mathematics is connected to actual humans seems to be a necessary part of any content presented at this conference.

During the lecture, I, as well as the woman sitting next to me, were having trouble following the mathematics that was being presented. We felt frustrated at the pace of the presentation. And we wondered if there were typos on the slides because we had trouble generating the same answers that were presented. Professor Arora did not seem to acknowledge this or want to engage the audience about our understanding. This was frustrating as I felt that a pause for discussion would have been pedagogically appropriate.

About 45 minutes into the session (9:45 AM), I heard one of the participants in the room ask if there would be room for discussion. The speaker answered that, yes, there would be time for discussion and just kept continuing lecturing. I noticed that me and the other participants around me all seemed disappointed that we did not start a discussion at that time.

When there were 15 minutes left in this 1.5-hour session (10:15 AM), Professor Arora opened up time for discussion. By this point, I had given up any attempt to follow along with the mathematics being presented. Professor Jayasree Subramanian, who was sitting a row behind me, raised her hand and was called on.

Professor Subramanian stood up and raised a few, well-organized points.

First, Professor Subramanian raised the point that the presenter was presenting Indian mathematics as one of only two mathematics cultures, European mathematics being the other. She questioned why Professor Arora did not acknowledge the other forms of mathematics such as Chinese or Egyptian or Inca mathematics and mentioned that not acknowledging other mathematical cultures is problematic.

*Second, Professor Subramanian brought up that Professor Arora did not mention that the idea of Vedic mathematics actually centers the idea of Brahmin supremacy within the unjust caste system that still pervades India today. Personally, I did not know much about this background. So, I appreciated that Professor Subramanian brought this up. For a conference like ICME, I feel we should be talking heavily about humanity and injustice, particularly within mathematics education. So this information helped me situate and understand culturally the role and space of what is labeled as Vedic mathematics.*

*Third, Professor Subramanian mentioned that some of the books and articles that were cited about Vedic mathematics in the introduction had been discredited. Professor Subramanian even mentioned that one the cited authors had disavowed the idea that a Vedic mathematics even exists. I appreciated this insight, as it revealed to me the ways propaganda and revisionist history are not found only in the mathematics context of the USA, but are universal. I also appreciated learning about the controversy over the ways that mathematics in India is situated and talked about. And I especially appreciated the connection back to the unjust caste system, particularly because it reinforced the little that I knew about the ways that Brahmin ideology often positions itself as the one and only true caste, and thereby the official holders of mathematics knowledge.*

*To me, these comments were great ways to start a conversation. Professor Subramanian spoke loudly so that the whole room could hear her. And she spoke with passion. Her comments seemed respectful and in line with opening up academic discourse.*

*After this, another participant stood up to speak. This participant mentioned that there was a space to engage in a critical unpacking of Vedic mathematics. But that, perhaps that critical conversation was not appropriate at this session. Then, because it was now 10:30 AM, the session was finished and we all walked outside.*

*After the session was over, I saw Professor Subramanian outside and I thanked her for her comments. I felt that without her comments, I would've left this session frustrated because it felt very much like a mathematics lecture and not a mathematics education workshop. I also felt that there were a number of ideas that came up in the session that were glossed over quickly, such as the role of the Vedic mathematicians, the connections of the Vedic mathematics to real-world mathematics, or even the ways that these ideas connected to mathematics teaching or teacher education.*

*Without Professor Subramanian's comments, I would've been frustrated and felt that I had spent an hour and a half in what was supposed to be a workshop and not really learned anything at all. But Professor Subramanian's comments helped connect the content presented to the realm of mathematics education and helped me better understand the sociopolitical space of how Vedic mathematics is situated.*

*Through Professor Subramanian's comments, I learned that the term Vedic is problematic, and that there are issues of power and caste and hierarchies deeply involved in this way of thinking about mathematics. This lens helped me better reflect on this session and the ways it connects to larger issues within our field of mathematics education globally.*

*In no way did I find anything that Professor Subramaniam said to be antagonistic or confrontational. Nor did I feel that there was any risk of violence or threats in the room. In fact, I felt that the conversations that came about because of Jayasree's comments led to a better conversation for everybody in the room because it helped connect the content to mathematics education.*

*I have since learned that Professor Subramanian was expelled from the ICME conference because of her comments in this session. To me, this decision feels unjust and unnecessarily harsh. From what I saw, Professor Subramanian was bringing up points to better connect this workshop to the goals of ICME. Without her comments, this would have been an inappropriate mathematics lecture that had no connection to ICME.*

*Even though I am an invited speaker and member of the ICME community, I ended up spending the rest of my Saturday missing sessions of the conference that I would have liked to have attended and participated in because I learned about this injustice to Professor Subramanian.*

*To me, it feels that Professor Subramanian is being unjustly targeted because she dared to call out injustice and the relationship of the Indian caste system to the content of this session. I also note that Professor Subramanian is an Indian woman who speaks with a strong and authoritative voice. Positioning her as a threat seems to invoke the same forms of misogyny and racism that continually oppress women of color globally.*

*This treatment of Professor Subramanian is unjust and unwarranted. This experience has made me question the decision-making ability of the ICME conference organizers and wonder if this conference is a safe space for women of color. Will the future of ICME be a space that lauds white supremacy, misogyny, and elitism within mathematics education? I have no interest in being a part of that ICME.*

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Theodore Chao is an associate professor of Mathematics Education in the Department of Teaching and Learning at The Ohio State University. His research agenda involves engaging all students and teachers regardless of social identity (race, gender, socioeconomic status, etc.) to fully see themselves as mathematical humans, particularly through technology. Chao is currently an associate editor for *Theory Into Practice* (TIP), an editorial panel member of *Mathematics Teacher Educator* (MTE), a steering committee member of the North American Chapter of the International Group for the Psychology of Mathematics Education (PME-NA), and an organizer for the Free Minds, Free People (FMFP) conference.

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